

Image courtesy: Sony



Sony Bravia KDL ZX1

Better backlighting techniques next time please

Kudos to Sony, since they managed not only to get their LED LCDs to India but they also gave us a sneak peak by sending one to our test labs. Naturally we were excited when we unboxed this beauty. Starting off we have one grouse – she's got ugly feet! The ZX1 has got a round, fat and ugly looking stand that is a far cry from the sleek, slim stands used by LG and Samsung. The bezel is a little wide but finished in brushed metal tones that gives a classy look. The entire body is black. Looking at her sideways we were surprised to see how slim she was. Sony claims 9.9mm at the slimmest point – pure swimsuit stuff, if only she had prettier feet.

The KDL ZX1 is a 40-inch panel and when you heft it one of the benefits of an LED backlighting system become apparent – it weighs no more than a 22-inch LCD monitor. Sony also thought it prudent to provide just one HDMI port on the display and the remaining connects on a “media receiver” box. In case you are wall mounting this makes sense. In terms of connectivity it's got Composite, Component with discrete RCA audio connects, a D-Sub connect and 3 HDMI ports. One Optical audio out is also provided as is a cable TV connect. On the front

of the receiver a USB input and an express card slot is also given. This receiver box connects to the display wirelessly – a unique feature because it eliminates any sort of cable clutter. Not only this it supports up to 1080i signals wirelessly. Wireless HD anyone? The frequency of the wireless signal is 5 GHz. We tested the integrity of the wireless data signal and are pleased to report that there is no lag and walking in between the receiver and display doesn't affect the transmission – super. Unfortunately 1080p isn't supported, if you wish to use this resolution you will need to hook the receiver up to the single HDMI port on the display.

When using DisplayMate one of the issues we noticed was of a delay (lag) when dimming or brightening the screen. This is probably due to the backlight LEDs mounting on the ends of the display along the sides. The light from these LEDs is channelled using some sort of reflective sheet, meaning the centre of the display is actually a few feet away from the actual light source. Although not noticeable when gaming or watching movies when a static screen is used the display will take a couple of seconds to adjust its backlight. Of course this is also the key to its slimmest – there is no way Sony could shoehorn in backlight LEDs

directly behind the LCD screen (as is done traditionally) and enclose everything in so slim a package. This prevents any sort of local dimming of LEDs around a particular area and this hurts the displays contrast ratio figure – our Spyder 3 Elite lists it at 664:1 – not bad, but we expected a figure closer to 1500:1. Luminance is also low – 162.5 cd/m². Owing to this and the decentralised LEDs the colours look a little dim and not as bright as we're used to seeing on the best panels. The reds and greens should be more vivid and lifelike but the KDL ZX1 cannot manage this.

Overall everything looks a little soft, thankfully even static images have no noise whatsoever and motion pictures lack any sort of banding. Movies have great contrast with good detailing and minimal noise in darker areas. Photos are clear and crisp – you may want tune the display properly to get slightly more vivid images. Blacks are deep and true and this monitor has a good black level. Even while gaming we had no issues except with F.E.A.R where the screen on the whole looks a little too dark at times. It's hard to imagine why Sony went with this weird design with the LEDs around the corners and sides.

For us, this display was a mixed bundle. The backlight delay issue is annoying as is the rather soft, sterile output. We can't comment historically because this is the first LED-based LCD display we've tested, but something tells us there are better models out there. Personally we wouldn't mind the display being a little thicker and heavier, but having a full LED-array behind the LCD panel, after all what's half an inch of thickness in comparison to pristine quality?

However, it has very good image quality with great contrast but we expected more for its price. It has got innovation in spades – with the unique backlighting technique and the wireless receiver unit, but priced at Rs. 2,00,000 we recommend skipping buying this and waiting for better panels – they're sure to be on the way.

Contact

Sony India

Phone: 1800-11-11-88 (Toll Free)

Email:

sonyindia.care@ap.sony.com

Web site: www.sony.co.in

Price: Rs. 1,99,900

Specifications

Size: 40-inches,

Resolution: 1080p,

Connects:

4 x HDMI, Component,

Composite, D-Sub,

Optical audio,

USB and Express Card slot

RATINGS

Features	8
Performance	7
Build quality	7.5
Value for money	3.5
Overall	6.5